

HOW THE WORLD PLAYS

Case Study

Exploring Four Decades of Regional Gaming Preferences (1971–2024)

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**Tools: PostgreSQL, Tableau,
Figma, Github.**

Why This Project?

The video game industry is one of the most influential forms of entertainment in the world, yet many analyses focus only on isolated statistics such as sales rankings or review scores. I wanted to take a different approach.

The goal of this project was to transform more than five decades of historical data into a coherent analytical narrative that explains how player preferences evolved across regions, how console generations reshaped the market, and how publishers and critics influenced commercial success.

More than building a dashboard, this project was an opportunity to combine technical analysis with storytelling, demonstrating that data visualization can communicate ideas just as effectively as it communicates numbers.

Executive Summary

The global video game industry has evolved through decades of technological innovation, changing player preferences, and increasing market competition. Understanding these long-term trends requires more than isolated statistics—it requires connecting historical events with consumer behavior.

How the World Plays is a data visualization project that analyzes over 64,000 video game releases published between 1971 and 2024, transforming raw sales data into a narrative-driven dashboard designed to answer five analytical questions about the evolution of the industry.

Rather than presenting disconnected visualizations, the project follows an editorial structure in which each chapter builds upon the previous one, guiding readers from market growth and regional preferences to publisher strategies and the relationship between critical reception and commercial success.

The result is an end-to-end analytics project combining SQL, PostgreSQL, Tableau Public, and Figma to demonstrate both technical proficiency and analytical storytelling.

Project Goals

The project was developed with four primary goals:

- **Transform a large historical dataset into an accessible analytical narrative.**
- **Identify long-term patterns that shaped the global video game market.**
- **Demonstrate an end-to-end data analytics workflow from SQL to visualization.**
- **Showcase how storytelling can improve the communication of analytical findings.**

Project Workflow

The project follows a structured analytics workflow designed to separate data preparation from visualization.

- 1. Raw data was imported into PostgreSQL.**
- 2. SQL was used to clean, aggregate, and prepare chapter-specific datasets.**
- 3. Processed CSV files were generated for each visualization.**
- 4. Tableau Public was used to build the dashboard.**
- 5. Figma was used during the planning phase to design the editorial layout before implementation.**

This approach ensured that every visualization was supported by reproducible SQL queries while maintaining a clear separation between data transformation and presentation.

Key Findings

The analysis revealed several notable patterns across more than four decades of video game history.

The industry reached its highest commercial performance in 2008 despite a larger number of titles being released the following year, highlighting the influence of blockbuster releases over sheer publishing volume.

Regional preferences showed consistent differences throughout the dataset. Japanese players strongly favored Role-Playing Games, while Shooter titles dominated North American and European markets, illustrating how cultural preferences shaped the global industry.

Console generations repeatedly redefined genre popularity, demonstrating that technological transitions influenced not only hardware adoption but also player behavior.

Publisher analysis revealed that commercial success is not solely determined by catalog size. Companies such as Rockstar Games achieved exceptional performance through a relatively small but highly successful portfolio.

Finally, critic scores exhibited only a weak correlation with commercial performance, suggesting that critical acclaim alone is not a reliable predictor of market success.

Lessons Learned

Developing *How the World Plays* reinforced that successful analytics projects are not defined solely by technical skills, but by the ability to communicate meaningful insights.

Throughout the project, I strengthened my SQL and data preparation skills, designed reproducible workflows using PostgreSQL and Tableau, and gained experience organizing large datasets into clear, narrative-driven visualizations.

Perhaps the most valuable lesson was understanding the importance of information hierarchy. Every visualization, annotation, and design decision was made with a single objective: helping readers understand the story behind the data without unnecessary complexity.

This project also highlighted the value of iteration. From refining SQL queries to redesigning dashboard layouts and improving documentation, each revision contributed to a more polished and coherent final product.

Skills Demonstrated

- SQL querying and data aggregation
- Data cleaning and preparation
- Exploratory data analysis
- Dashboard design
- Information hierarchy
- Data storytelling
- Visual communication
- Tableau Public development
- Project documentation
- Analytical thinking

Conclusion

How the World Plays demonstrates how historical data can be transformed into meaningful analytical narratives through thoughtful visualization and structured storytelling.

Rather than focusing solely on descriptive metrics, the project emphasizes context, interpretation, and communication—turning decades of market data into a cohesive exploration of how players, platforms, publishers, and critics collectively shaped the evolution of the global video game industry.
